that we weren't doing anything of importance in connection with Operation Crossroads; that our inspection of the material exposed to the blast could be performed by any eighteen-year-old nonspecialist and that, in fact, the eighteen-year-olds and we were being assigned to the work without distinction among us. We were just being wasted on

the project, to make various officers seem more important, and ought to be sent back to our original units—where we could apply for discharge.

The trouble was that we could not appeal on this basis to anyone in the military. We had to go through channels, starting with our immediate superior, who would, of course, quash it at once and give us much trouble in the process.

Nor could we write to Congress, since that was forbidden.

It occurred to me, then, that we could write to Dr. Bradley Dewey, who was head of the American Chemical Society. After all, the ACS was my professional society, and I was a member in good standing. The other specialists were also either chemists or chemical engineers.

If Dr. Dewey cared to take the matter further, that would be his responsibility. We would certainly be careful not to ask him to do anything. A copy would also be sent to Credo's wife, who knew a senator. If she happened to take it to him, that was not our fault either.

I typed up the letter carefully on April 1 (it didn't occur to me that it might be taken as an April Fool joke, or I would have dated it March 31.) It covered three pages and came, I should judge, to about thirteen hundred words. The composition was entirely mine, and I still have a copy of it, but it is too tedious to quote, except perhaps for the last paragraph:

"Perhaps this is a sample of a more general misuse of men thoughout the Army. If so, it should be investigated, for the overall good of America's scientific future."

Once it was done, there came the matter of signing it and, to my amazement, after having enthusiastically concurred in the writing of the letter, and having energetically approved my first draft, there came a general reluctance to sign. In particular, no one wanted to sign first, since each claimed that the first signer would be assumed to be the ringleader.

I said, "Well, then, since I'm the ringleader, I'll sign first. Who wants to be